

CHAPTER 15 — No Grandmother

The sat-nav objected first.

Recalculating.

The calm electronic voice filled the car as the grandmother's exit disappeared behind them.

Elias touched the screen and cancelled the route.

For several seconds, the map remained centred on the motorway with nowhere selected. A blue arrow moved forward through empty digital space.

Zoe watched it from the back seat.

"You already knew where you were going," she said.

"No."

"You said somewhere he doesn't know to look."

"I know a place. That isn't the same as knowing whether we should use it."

Her grip tightened around the backpack.

"That sounds like another way of saying you've already decided."

"It isn't."

The motorway widened around them. Evening traffic had begun to thicken: commuters, delivery vans, families returning from somewhere with bags pressed against rear windows. Every vehicle appeared to possess a destination agreed upon by everyone inside it.

Elias drove without one displayed.

Zoe looked through the rear window.

The same white van had remained behind them since before the exit. It moved into the next lane, accelerated past and continued without slowing.

She watched until it disappeared.

"What happens when Mac realises?" she asked.

"If he hasn't already, he will when I miss the check-in."

"When is that?"

"Soon."

"You could say you made a mistake."

"He didn't hire me because I make mistakes with addresses."

The answer contained no pride. Only fact.

Zoe shifted the backpack closer to her body.

"So this is the part where you decide what happens to me instead."

Elias looked at her in the mirror.

"No."

"It sounds like it."

"It probably does."

"That isn't an answer."

"No," he said. "It isn't."

A brown road sign appeared ahead, marking a small rest area beyond the next junction.

Elias indicated.

"Where are we going?"

"Somewhere we can stop, see what follows us in and leave through another exit."

Zoe's eyes moved to the door handle.

Elias noticed.

"Once we stop, the doors stay unlocked. You can leave if you choose."

"You could still catch me."

"Yes."

"You caught me at the airport."

"You were trying to drive a car you could barely see out of."

"I could see."

"You nearly hit a concrete pillar."

"It was badly placed."

One corner of her mouth moved.

Elias took the junction.

"I won't chase you unless you walk into traffic," he said.

"That's a condition."

"It's a safety boundary."

"Sounds like something adults say when they mean a rule."

"Sometimes rules stop people being run over."

The rest area appeared beyond a stand of trees.

It had a separate entrance and exit, two rows of parking spaces and a footpath leading towards open fields. Elias drove through once before choosing a space with a clear view of both access roads.

No vehicle followed them in.

The rest area contained a locked toilet block, three picnic tables and a vending machine with half its lights missing.

Elias parked facing the exit.

He switched off the engine but kept the keys in his hand.

Zoe waited.

Elias opened his door.

"I need the map."

"What map?"

"The paper one."

"You have a sat-nav."

"I also have a boss who knows the address programmed into it."

He walked to the boot.

Zoe remained inside for two seconds, then got out with the backpack on both shoulders.

Elias lifted the boot lid. Beneath an old jacket, a first-aid kit and the angle grinder he had used that morning, he found a road atlas with a broken spine.

Zoe stared at the grinder.

"That was for the clamp," he said.

"I didn't ask."

"You were going to."

"I was deciding whether I wanted to."

He placed the atlas on the roof.

Wind caught the pages and turned half the country at once. Elias pinned them with one forearm.

The map was older than Zoe. Several roads had been added in pen. Others were crossed out. Small circles and dates appeared beside towns whose names meant nothing to her.

"You mark your maps," she said.

"I used to."

"For work?"

"For not getting lost."

"That's not what those marks are."

"No."

He found the region he wanted and followed a road with one finger. Zoe stood on the opposite side of the roof. "What is the place?"

"A cottage."

"Whose?"

"Legally? A name I stopped using."

"And actually?"

"Mine."

"You own a cottage."

"I stopped going."

"When?"

"A

long time ago." "Before Mac?"

"Yes."

"Before you became his driver?"

"Yes."

"Before the Reaper disappeared?"

Elias's finger stopped on the map. Traffic moved along the distant road beyond the trees. "Jackie told you more than a story," he said.

"She told me enough to recognise when adults leave parts out."

He closed the atlas halfway, then opened it again. "Does Mac know about the cottage?" she asked.

"Not that I know of."

"Cain?"

"Not that I know of."

"Anyone?"

"Possibly people who are dead."

"That isn't the same as nobody."

"No," Elias said.

"It isn't."

Zoe looked down at the map. "At least that sounds true."

"How far?" she asked.

"Several hours."

"It's already evening."

"We don't have to go."

"Where else?"

"That's what we're deciding."

Elias turned the atlas so the writing faced her. "The police are one option."

"No."

"A hospital."

"No."

"Somewhere public until morning."

"Cain's people found us at a service station."

"They found the route Mac gave them."

"They found your car."

Elias looked towards the hatchback. "That matters," he said.

"We can abandon it," he continued.

"Train, bus or hire car."

"Using whose name?"

He looked back at her. "Exactly."

The wind turned another page. Elias flattened it. "There are people I could call," he said.

"People who might help."

"You trust them?"

"No."

"Then they aren't options."

"One might be."

"Might?"

"That is the honest version."

Zoe looked at the coloured roads.

"What about Jackie?"

"We get somewhere we can think, then work out how to find her."

"That could be too late."

"It may already be too late."

Her hands stopped on the backpack straps.

Elias did not soften the statement.

"I'm not telling you that because I've given up," he said. "I'm telling you because I won't promise something I can't deliver."

"You could have said we'll find her."

"Yes."

"Most adults would."

"Most adults have been lying to you all week."

Zoe looked towards the field.

"I don't know what I'm meant to choose."

It was the first thing she had said that sounded thirteen.

Elias closed the atlas.

"You don't have to solve all of it. Choose the next part."

"What happens at the cottage?"

"We check it. If it's compromised, we leave."

"And if it isn't?"

"You sleep. I work out who knows what. We copy whatever is on that drive without connecting it to anything that can report back."

"You won't open it without me."

"No."

"You won't take the folder."

"No."

"You won't call Mac."

"No."

"You won't take me somewhere else while I'm asleep."

Elias looked at her across the roof of the car.

"No."

Zoe's fingers closed around one strap.

"What do you get?"

"A worse week."

"That isn't an answer."

"No," he said. "But it's the one I have."

"What if I decide to leave after we get there?"

"I'll tell you what's outside, how far the nearest road is and what will happen if you walk it alone."

"And then?"

"And then you decide."

"You won't stop me?"

"I will tell you when an option is dangerous. I won't call it safe just because I prefer it."

"And if I still choose it?"

"Then I deal with the choice you made, not the one I wanted."

Zoe looked at the road atlas again.

"The cottage," she said.

Elias nodded once.

Not approval.

Acceptance.

He reopened the atlas.

"There are two sensible routes. The faster one uses the motorway most of the way. More cameras, more services, easier to follow. The other adds time and takes us through smaller roads after dark."

"You said sensible."

"I said two sensible routes. I didn't say either was good."

Zoe studied them.

The motorway route was a thick blue line. The other crossed it, narrowed and wandered through hills and towns too small to earn bold print.

"Which would you choose?" she asked.

"The slower one."

"Then why ask me?"

"Because you're in the car."

"That's it?"

"That's enough."

Zoe placed one finger on the smaller road.

"This one."

Elias folded the atlas to the relevant page and handed it to her.

"Keep that open."

"You're making me navigate."

"I'm asking you to tell me when this junction appears."

"That sounds like navigation."

"It's one junction."

"You'll blame me if we miss it."

"I'll blame the road."

She took the atlas.

Elias opened the passenger door.

Zoe remained beside the rear one.

"You can sit where you want," he said.

"Why?"

"Because the back seat was where I put you when I was still treating you like a delivery."

The word remained between them.

He did not excuse it.

Zoe looked into the front of the hatchback. The plastic beneath the steering column still hung slightly loose from where she had pulled it apart at the airport. The crumpled yellow parking sticker remained in the passenger footwell.

"Is that the clamp notice?" she asked.

"Yes."

"You kept it."

"I forgot it."

"You keep forgetting important things."

"Only the expensive ones."

She opened the front door and picked up the sticker.

The adhesive had collected grit along one edge. A threatening paragraph warned of prosecution, recovery fees and further action.

"You cut it off," she said.

"It was obstructing the wheel."

"That's not usually a legal defence."

"I'm hoping the magistrate enjoys technical language."

Zoe placed the notice in the door pocket and climbed into the passenger seat.

She kept the backpack on her lap.

Elias did not tell her to put on the seat belt.

She did it herself.

When he started the engine, the sat-nav returned to the blank map.

He removed the phone from its mount.

The screen showed three missed calls from Mac.

A fourth arrived while they watched.

The X-Files theme began to whistle through the car.

Zoe looked at the name.

"Are you going to answer?"

"No."

"If you switch it off, he'll know."

"The check-in has already passed."

Elias rejected the call.

A message appeared immediately.

CALL ME. NOW.

Another followed before he could lock the screen.

YOU DO NOT UNDERSTAND WHAT YOU ARE CARRYING.

Zoe read it.

"He called me a delivery," she said.

"No."

"He called me what you're carrying."

Elias looked at the message again.

Then he held down the power button.

The phone went dark.

"That was your job," Zoe said.

"Yes."

"Your boss might try to kill you."

"He'll hire someone first."

The answer came too quickly.

"You've thought about this."

"I've known men like Mac longer than I've worked for him."

"You said he didn't know who you were."

"He knows enough to be dangerous. He has spent years pretending the

rest didn't matter."

"And Cain?"

"What I've seen says Cain is careful."

Elias opened his door again.

He took the phone to the boot, removed the SIM and snapped it between his fingers. From beneath the first-aid kit he retrieved a small signal-blocking pouch, sealed the handset inside and buried it beneath the old jacket.

Zoe watched from the passenger seat.

"Do you always carry one of those?"

"I used to carry several."

"You stopped?"

"I tried."

He closed the boot and returned to the driver's seat.

The phone had not caused the first pursuit, and isolating it would not make the car invisible. It removed one obvious path. That was all.

Elias started the engine.

They left the motorway forty minutes later.

The slip road curved beneath the carriageway and released them onto an older road bordered by warehouses, tyre shops and darkened retail units. The sun had dropped behind the roofs. Sodium lights came on one by one.

Zoe watched the signs from the passenger seat.

"Left at the second roundabout," she said.

Elias glanced at the atlas.

"First."

"It says second."

"That one was built after the map."

"You gave me an outdated map."

"I gave you the one I had."

"This is how people end up in lakes."

"Not many roundabouts lead directly into lakes."

"That sounds like something someone says before driving into one."

He took the first exit.

The road narrowed gradually. Warehouses became terraces, terraces became scattered houses, then fields. The last of the daylight remained above the hills in a thin red line.

Zoe's head rested against the window for several miles before she straightened again.

"You can sleep," Elias said.

"No."

"You didn't sleep on the plane."

"No."

"Or last night."

"No."

"You're going to lose that argument with your body."

"I'm not arguing."

Her eyes closed as she said it.

They opened again almost immediately.

At the next red light, Elias reached behind his seat and pulled the old jacket from the rear footwell. He placed it between them.

"What's that?"

"A jacket."

"I can see that."

"You looked cold."

"I'm not."

"Then ignore it."

The light changed.

Zoe waited until they had passed three more junctions before pulling the jacket over herself.

The atlas stayed open beneath one hand.

"Elias."

"Yes."

"If the cottage belongs to another name, what do I call you there?"

"Elias."

"Is that your real name?"

"It's the one I use."

"That isn't what I asked."

"No."

She was quiet for a while.

"Zoe might not be my real name either."

Elias looked across at her, then returned his eyes to the road.

The folder had changed the meaning of almost every fact she possessed about herself. Her voice did not change when she said it.

"What do you want me to call you?" he asked.

"Zoe."

"Then that's your name."

"You make it sound simple."

"It should be."

"It isn't."

"No," he said. "It isn't."

The road bent through a village where every shop had closed except a small grocery beneath a flickering sign. Elias checked the fuel gauge and drove past.

"You need petrol," Zoe said.

"Soon."

"You also need food."

"So do you."

"I ate on the plane."

"Three mouthfuls of pasta and a bread roll."

She turned towards him.

"How do you know?"

"You told me."

"I did not."

"You said you couldn't eat after thinking about Jackie. I made an estimate."

"That's annoying."

"I get that a lot."

At the edge of the next town, Elias slowed beside an independent petrol station with two pumps and a shop barely larger than the counter inside it.

He drove past once.

The forecourt had one visible camera above the shop entrance and no vehicle waiting near either exit. He circled the block, returned and parked where he could see the road in both directions.

"I'm getting fuel and food," he said. "You can come in or stay here. Doors remain unlocked either way."

Zoe looked through the shop window. One elderly man sat behind the till reading a newspaper. A woman in work clothes compared packets of crisps near the refrigerator.

"I'm coming."

Inside, the fluorescent lights buzzed.

Elias took bottled water, bread, cheese, fruit and two packets of biscuits. Zoe removed the cheese and replaced it with hummus.

"That costs more," he said.

"You said I could choose."

"I said you could come inside."

She kept the hummus.

At the counter, Elias paid cash.

The elderly man glanced at Zoe, at the late hour, then at Elias.

"Long way to go?" he asked.

Elias looked through the glass towards the road.

"Long enough."

The man accepted that and returned to his newspaper.

The stop lasted less than six minutes.

Outside, Zoe ate half a banana beside the car while Elias filled the tank.

Ordinary fuel smell.

Ordinary traffic.

Ordinary light spilling onto wet tarmac.

For several minutes, nobody told her where to stand.

They drove again.

The towns became smaller. Streetlights disappeared. The road rose and fell through darkness, visible only within the reach of the headlamps.

Zoe finished the banana and held the unopened biscuits.

"You can have them," Elias said.

"They're yours."

"I bought them."

"That's what I said."

"I bought them for the car."

"The car doesn't eat biscuits."

"You haven't seen it on a bad morning."

She placed the packet between them rather than taking it.

Half an hour later, Elias opened it. He ate one and left the rest where they were.

Zoe took one without comment.

The atlas page trembled slightly with the vibration of the road.

"Next turning is after a bridge," she said.

"How far?"

She traced the line.

"Two miles. Maybe three. The scale is worn off."

"Useful map."

"You chose it."

"I chose the route. You chose the map."

"You handed it to me."

“That sounds difficult to prove.”

The bridge appeared in the headlights.

Zoe sat forward.

“There.”

Elias slowed.

A narrow road opened beyond it, unlit and easy to miss.

He turned.

The road climbed between hedges that caught the headlamps and vanished behind them.

Mac knew the check-in had failed. He had been ignored, disconnected and denied the delivery he believed belonged to him.

He would respond.

Elias did not know when or through whom.

Beside him, Zoe held the map with both hands.

This time, the next turn had been chosen with her rather than for her.